

Global and Strategic Partners

India's cultural and social relations with Japan date back to the 6th century when Buddhism was introduced in Japan. In the ancient era, India was known as "the Heaven in the West" among the Japanese people.

Over the centuries, however, India and Japan did not build on this strong foundation. Japan never approved of India's nuclear ambitions and bilateral relations hit a new low when India conducted a nuclear test in 1998.

But things changed swiftly for good soon after. Japanese Prime Minister Yoshiro Mori's visit to India in 2000 paved a fresh path for bringing the two countries together. Bilateral visits by Prime Ministers and Cabinet Ministers of both the countries have increased significantly since then.

Previous Prime Minister Shinzo Abe's visit to India in August 2007, where he was accompanied by more than 175 top business leaders from Japan, resulted in both the countries reaching an agreement to form a "Strategic Global Partnership". Prime Minister Manmohan Singh is scheduled to visit Japan later this year. Dr. Singh's previous visit in December 2006 was a historic one as he signed a Joint Statement on Global and Strategic Partnership with Prime Minister Abe.

